REFORM OF THE UN

The UN, facing stiff challenges in the present century with its authority being questioned often and its existence being put under great pressure, needs a makeover and needs reinvention. A revitalized UN is the need of the hour. Given the unequal representative structure of the Security Council, the history of inaction of the Security Council during the Cold War, tussle between the P-5 members of the Security Council, the veto factor and, furthermore, hijacking of the Security Council in the post-Cold War era by the United States have undermined the prestige and importance of the UN. The US action in Serbia over the Kosovo issue followed by NATO bombing of Kosovo, US invasion of Iraq and Afghanistan bypassing the UN—all have given deadly blow to the credibility of this world organization. Even the Soviet occupation of Afghanistan in 1979 and bombing in Chechnya and Georgia have also proved the ineffectiveness of the UN system. Further, the allegation of corruption in the Oil-for-Food Programme tarnished the image of this world body. An Independent Inquiry Committee led by Paul Volcker, which unearthed the scandal, suggested measures to strengthen the UN. There were also accusations of sexual exploitation in peacekeeping missions and the Zeid Report entitled “A Comprehensive Strategy to Eliminate Future Sexual Exploitation and Abuse in United Nations Peacekeeping Operations” made recommendations for remedial measures. Reform of the world organization is the need of the hour. Many efforts have been made to revitalize this world body and some measures have also been implemented but the organization has miles to go before some actual structural adjustments can be introduced which would enable it to run effectively.

The Atlantic Council Working Group (1977) on the United Nations proposed a number of reform strategies to revitalize the working of the UN. Some of these strategies were:

- Strengthening of the machinery of pacific settlement of disputes.